Mini-Project (ML for Time Series) – Soft-DTW: a Differentiable Loss Function for Time-Series – MVA 2026/2027

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[TODO: second student, if any]

1 Introduction and contributions

A time series can be defined as a matrix of the form $x = (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times p}$, i.e. a sequence of n observations $x_i \in \mathbb{R}^p$ ordered in time. So, given two time series $x \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times p}$ and $y \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times p}$, a fundamental problem arises: how can we work with them jointly if they have different supports? This is where DTW comes into play. DTW [8] is a method that compares two series by first finding the cheapest monotone alignment between their time steps, so that shifts, local stretches and different lengths are not counted as differences; it is computed by dynamic programming in $O(nm)$ time. However, this method has some flaws, the biggest one being that it is not differentiable; therefore, it is not easy to use in a machine learning context. That is why Cuturi and Blondel [2] introduced soft-DTW, a differentiable version of DTW with the same cost as DTW and with a gradient that allows us to apply ML tools. The paper uses it to compute barycenters, run k-means, classify with nearest centroids and train networks that output time series.

Contributions and work repartition. **Implementation:** we implemented soft-DTW from scratch (forward and backward recursions in Numba, a PyTorch loss with the hand-written backward, and an anti-diagonal PyTorch version that runs on GPU). `tslearn` [10] is only used to load the UCR data, as the DBA baseline and as a numerical cross-check. **Reproduction:** we reproduce, on 10–13 UCR datasets, the paper's barycenter (Table 1), k-means (Table 2), nearest-centroid (Fig. 7) and forecasting (Table 3) experiments. **Beyond the paper:** (i) we report magnitudes and computational costs that the paper omits, and add the baselines it does not compare to (Euclidean nearest centroid, 1-NN DTW); (ii) we show that soft-DTW is one instance of a soft dynamic program with edge costs [6], implement it generically and derive from it a soft-DTW with a warping penalty that charges a cost ω for every time-stretching step, together with the debiased (divergence) version of soft-DTW [1]; (iii) following the paper's own protocol, we use these variants as surrogates to compute DTW barycenters and compare them under the hard DTW loss, both on the averaged series and on unseen series of the same class. **Work repartition:** [TODO: describe the split between the two students].

2 Method

DTW. Let $x \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times p}$ and $y \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times p}$ be two time series. Matching x_i with y_j costs $\delta_{i,j} = \|x_i - y_j\|^2$, and these costs form the matrix $\Delta(x, y) = [\delta_{i,j}]_{i,j} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times m}$. An *alignment* is a path in this matrix from cell $(1, 1)$ to cell (n, m) made of three kinds of steps: $\searrow$ (both series advance), $\downarrow$ (x advances while y stays at the same point y_j) and $\rightarrow$ (y advances while x stays at x_i). We encode it as a binary matrix

$A \in \{0,1\}^{n\times m}$, with $A_{i,j} = 1$ if the path visits cell (i,j), and write $\mathcal{A}_{n,m}$ for the set of all alignments. The cost of an alignment is the sum of the costs of the cells it visits, $\langle A, \Delta\rangle = \sum_{i,j} A_{i,j}\,\delta_{i,j}$, and DTW is the cost of the cheapest one:

$$\mathrm{dtw}(x,y) = \min_{A\in\mathcal{A}_{n,m}} \langle A, \Delta(x,y)\rangle. \tag{1}$$

Soft-DTW. Soft-DTW replaces this minimum by the *soft-minimum* with smoothing parameter $\gamma > 0$,

$$\min{}^{\gamma}(a_1,\dots,a_k) = -\gamma \log \sum_{l=1}^{k} e^{-a_l/\gamma}. \tag{2}$$

Therefore, soft-DTW is the soft-minimum of the costs of all alignments:

$$\mathrm{dtw}_\gamma(x,y) = \min_{A\in\mathcal{A}_{n,m}}{}^{\gamma} \langle A, \Delta(x,y)\rangle = -\gamma \log \sum_{A\in\mathcal{A}_{n,m}} e^{-\langle A,\Delta(x,y)\rangle/\gamma}. \tag{3}$$

The soft-minimum tends to $\min(a_1,\dots,a_k)$ as $\gamma \to 0$ (we write $\min^0 = \min$), but unlike the minimum it is a smooth function of its arguments: its derivative with respect to a_l is the softmax weight $e^{-a_l/\gamma} / \sum_{l'} e^{-a_{l'}/\gamma} \in (0,1)$, so the smallest values weigh most but all of them contribute. Hence dtw_γ is smooth (infinitely differentiable) in Δ, and so in x, whereas dtw has kinks wherever the optimal path changes.

Forward pass (Algorithm 1). It is impossible to find the minimum by computing all the alignments, as $|\mathcal{A}_{n,m}|$ is a Delannoy number, which grows exponentially with n and m; therefore, we need a dynamic programming approach. Both DTW and soft-DTW are computed by Bellman's recursion: with $r_{0,0} = 0$ and $r_{i,0} = r_{0,j} = +\infty$,

$$r_{i,j} = \delta_{i,j} + \min{}^{\gamma}\{r_{i-1,j-1},\, r_{i-1,j},\, r_{i,j-1}\}, \qquad \mathrm{dtw}_\gamma(x,y) = r_{n,m}, \tag{4}$$

in $O(nm)$ time.

Gradient (Algorithm 2). By the chain rule, $\nabla_x \mathrm{dtw}_\gamma = (\partial\Delta/\partial x)^\top E$ with $E = \partial r_{n,m}/\partial\Delta = \mathbb{E}_\gamma[A]$, the expected alignment under the Gibbs distribution $p_\gamma(A) \propto e^{-\langle A,\Delta\rangle/\gamma}$: $e_{i,j}$ is the probability that a random path visits cell (i,j). Computing $\mathbb{E}_\gamma[A]$ directly costs $O(n^2m^2)$; the paper instead back-propagates through the recursion. Since $r_{i,j}$ only influences its three successors,

$$e_{i,j} = \sum_{(k,l)\in\{(i+1,j),(i,j+1),(i+1,j+1)\}} e_{k,l}\, \exp\big((r_{k,l} - r_{i,j} - \delta_{k,l})/\gamma\big), \qquad e_{n,m} = 1, \tag{5}$$

where each exponential is the softmax weight of $r_{i,j}$ inside $r_{k,l}$, and can be read directly from the table $R = [r_{i,j}]$ computed in the forward pass, which is therefore kept in memory ($O(nm)$ instead of $O(n)$ for DTW alone). For the squared Euclidean cost, $\nabla_{x_i}\mathrm{dtw}_\gamma = 2\sum_j e_{i,j}(x_i - y_j)$: each x_i is pulled towards the y_j it is likely aligned with. As $\gamma \to 0$, E tends to the optimal DTW path $A^\star$, whose discontinuous dependence on x is what soft-DTW removes (Fig. 1).

Learning with soft-DTW. The barycenter of $y_1,\dots,y_N$ solves $\min_{x\in\mathbb{R}^{n\times p}} \sum_i \frac{\lambda_i}{m_i}\mathrm{dtw}_\gamma(x,y_i)$ (Eq. 4 of the paper), a smooth but non-convex problem that we solve with L-BFGS. k-means alternates assignment and barycenter steps under dtw_γ; the nearest-centroid classifier uses one barycenter per class; and for forecasting dtw_γ is the training loss of a network (our PyTorch `autograd.Function`).

A family of soft alignment distances (our extension). Soft-DTW is one instance of a soft dynamic program on the alignment grid [6], in which each of the three edges entering cell (i, j) has its own cost:

$$r_{i,j} = \min^{\gamma}\{r_{i-1,j-1} + c_{i,j}^{\searrow},\ r_{i-1,j} + c_{i,j}^{\downarrow},\ r_{i,j-1} + c_{i,j}^{\rightarrow}\}. \tag{6}$$

The same backward pass returns the expected usage of every edge, from which the gradient w.r.t. x follows by the chain rule. Choosing the edge costs gives: soft-DTW ($c = \delta_{i,j}$ for all edges); *soft-DTW with a warping penalty* (soft-DTW$_\omega$), $c^{\downarrow} = c^{\rightarrow} = \delta_{i,j} + \omega$: every step that stretches time pays a fixed penalty ω (the soft counterpart of "amerced" DTW [4]). For soft-DTW$_\omega$, $\omega = 0$ recovers soft-DTW, $\omega \to \infty$ forbids warping (Euclidean distance for equal lengths), and $\partial r_{n,m}/\partial\omega$ is the expected number of warping steps. This matters because the entropic smoothing of soft-DTW carries a data-independent prior: for large γ, E tends to the uniform average over paths, concentrated around the diagonal whatever the data (Fig. 1, right); step costs reshape this prior. Finally, smoothing introduces a bias: $S(x, x) \neq 0$ (for soft-DTW, $\mathrm{dtw}_\gamma(x, x) < 0$), so a series is not at distance zero from itself. Each member S can be debiased into the divergence $D(x, y) = S(x, y) - \frac{1}{2}S(x, x) - \frac{1}{2}S(y, y)$, which vanishes at $x = y$ [1].

3 Data

We use 13 univariate datasets of the UCR archive [3] (loaded with `tslearn`), chosen to span domains (ECG, motion, image outlines, power demand, synthetic), lengths (24 to 512) and numbers of classes (2 to 60), while keeping the quadratic cost of DTW manageable on a laptop (Table 1). The paper used a subset of 79 datasets without stating the selection criterion (and, as its Table 2 percentages imply, only 57–58 of them for k-means); our tables are a smaller but diverse replication, with 10–13 datasets depending on the cost of each experiment.

Diagnosis. All series are z-normalised (mean 0, standard deviation 1 per series), so pointwise costs $\delta_{i,j}$ are $O(1)$ and the smoothing parameter γ has a comparable meaning across datasets; this is not true for raw data, where γ should scale with the typical cost. To check whether the data actually contain the temporal distortions DTW is designed for, we drew 200 random pairs of series of the same class per dataset and measured (i) the global lag maximising their cross-correlation and (ii) the fraction of the Euclidean cost removed by DTW, $1 - \mathrm{dtw}/\|x - y\|^2$. Two regimes appear. Datasets such as CBF, Trace, SyntheticControl or ECG200 contain large global shifts (10% of the pairs are shifted by 15–35% of the length). Others (Coffee, ArrowHead, Plane) are globally aligned (lag 0), yet DTW still removes 68–90% of the Euclidean cost: the variability is made of *local* accelerations and stretches, which a global shift cannot fix but warping can. In every dataset DTW removes between 48% and 96% of the within-class Euclidean cost, which supports using an elastic geometry on all of them.

4 Results

4.1 Implementation and verification

Forward and backward passes are compiled with Numba, with the soft-minimum computed in a numerically stable way (log-sum-exp trick); a PyTorch `autograd.Function` calls them, and a second, pure PyTorch version processes whole anti-diagonals at once ($n + m$ sequential steps instead

Table 1: Datasets and diagnosis. Lag: global shift between two series of the same class (cross-correlation), in % of the length (median / 90th percentile). DTW gain: median share of the within-class Euclidean cost removed by DTW.

Dataset	Train	Test	Length	Classes	Lag % (med / p90)	DTW gain
ItalyPowerDemand	67	1029	24	2	0.0 / 8.3	0.48
SyntheticControl	300	300	60	6	3.3 / 35.2	0.76
TwoLeadECG	23	1139	82	2	2.4 / 6.1	0.90
ECG200	100	100	96	2	2.1 / 19.8	0.79
MedicalImages	381	760	99	10	1.0 / 8.2	0.78
CBF	30	900	128	3	4.7 / 25.8	0.85
ECGFiveDays	23	861	136	2	1.5 / 3.7	0.90
Plane	105	105	144	7	0.0 / 0.7	0.90
GunPoint	50	150	150	2	0.7 / 5.3	0.77
ArrowHead	36	175	251	3	0.0 / 0.0	0.85
Trace	100	100	275	4	4.7 / 14.6	0.96
Coffee	28	28	286	2	0.0 / 0.0	0.68
ShapesAll	600	600	512	60	1.2 / 27.1	0.93

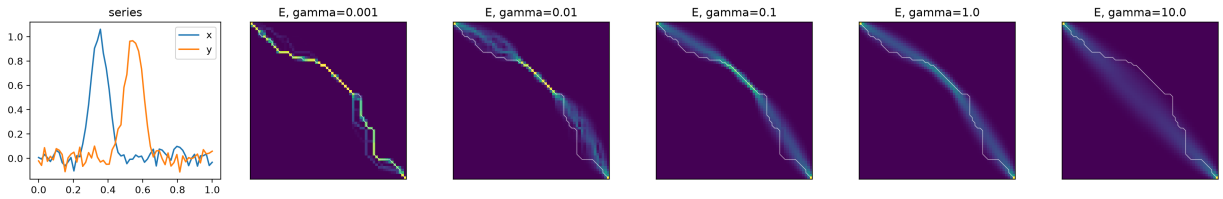


Figure 1: Expected alignment $E = \mathbb{E}_\gamma[A]$ between two shifted bumps for increasing γ; white: optimal DTW path. For $\gamma = 10$ the alignment ignores the data and concentrates around the diagonal.

of nm), which is the scheme GPU implementations use. We check the value and E against *brute-force enumeration of every alignment* (all Delannoy paths, $n, m \leq 5$, $\gamma \in [10^{-2}, 10]$, error $< 10^{-10}$), the gradient against finite differences, the bound $\mathrm{dtw} - \gamma \log |\mathcal{A}| \leq \mathrm{dtw}_\gamma \leq \mathrm{dtw}$, the agreement with `tslearn`, and the custom backward against autograd. All variants scale as $O(nm)$ (fitted log-log slopes 2.02–2.04), but constants differ by orders of magnitude: for $n = m = 64$ forward+backward takes 0.3 ms with Numba, 20 ms with the same code in pure Python and 0.75 s with a cell-by-cell PyTorch forward differentiated by autograd, which confirms the paper's remark that a custom backward is essential. Fig. 1 shows how E moves from the hard DTW path ($\gamma \to 0$) to a diffuse band, and for large γ to a data-independent diagonal band.

4.2 Barycenters and k-means (Tables 1–2 of the paper)

Protocol as in the paper: for each dataset, 10 random draws of 10 series of one class; barycenters from the same initialisation (random $\mathcal{N}(0, 1)$ or Euclidean mean) with at most 100 iterations; soft-DTW with L-BFGS, DBA [7] (`tslearn`) and a batch subgradient method with backtracking line search [9]. All methods are scored with the *hard* DTW objective (Eq. 4 with $\gamma = 0$), which is the objective DBA itself minimises. k-means uses k = number of classes, at most 30 Lloyd and 100 barycenter iterations, training sets capped at 100 series, 3 random initialisations (random series) and a Euclidean k-means initialisation.

Table 2 reproduces the paper's trends closely: small γ beats DBA almost always, $\gamma = 1$ rarely does,

Table 2: Percentage of datasets on which soft-DTW reaches a lower hard-DTW loss than DBA / the subgradient method. Ours (12 datasets for barycenters, 10 for k-means) vs. the paper (79 datasets) in parentheses.

		$\gamma = 1$	$\gamma = 0.1$	$\gamma = 0.01$	$\gamma = 0.001$
Barycenters	vs DBA, random init	58 (41)	92 (94)	100 (100)	100 (97)
	vs DBA, Euclidean init	8 (4)	25 (47)	75 (80)	100 (90)
	vs subgrad., random init	75 (96)	100 (97)	100 (97)	100 (97)
	vs subgrad., Euclidean init	17 (35)	75 (72)	92 (92)	100 (97)
k-means	vs DBA, random init	10 (16)	50 (25)	70 (60)	90 (77)
	vs DBA, Euclidean init	10 (29)	10 (24)	60 (55)	90 (69)
	vs subgrad., random init	20 (42)	60 (58)	100 (76)	90 (96)
	vs subgrad., Euclidean init	10 (46)	10 (50)	90 (66)	100 (84)

and the gap is larger from a random start. The paper only reports win rates; magnitudes and costs nuance the picture. *Barycenters:* from a random start the median soft-DTW/DBA loss ratio is 0.86 ($\gamma = 0.01$), down to 0.26 on Plane ($\gamma = 0.1$), where DBA is trapped in a poor local minimum; from the Euclidean mean, which is already a good start, the gain is only 3–4% (median ratio 0.97). *k-means:* gains shrink further (median ratio 0.97 for $\gamma \leq 0.01$). *Cost:* with $\gamma = 0.001$ a soft-DTW barycenter takes 14× (and a k-means run 16×) the time of DBA, because the objective becomes nearly non-smooth and L-BFGS needs many more steps. Conversely, $\gamma = 1$ gives visually smooth barycenters but losses up to 3× that of DBA: smoothness and fidelity to DTW pull in opposite directions, and the hard-DTW metric only rewards the latter. Finally, the subgradient baseline is very sensitive to its step size (from a random start it stalls 30× above DBA on Coffee and Trace), which inflates the win rates against it.

4.3 Nearest-centroid classification (Fig. 7 of the paper)

Following the paper, data are pooled and split 50/25/25 (3 random stratified splits) and γ is selected on validation among 15 log-spaced values in $[10^{-3}, 10]$. Soft-DTW centroids are at least as accurate as DBA centroids on 83% of the datasets (paper: 75%), with mean accuracy 0.86 vs 0.81. Two baselines the paper does not report put this in context: Euclidean centroids reach 0.77, but **1-NN DTW reaches** 0.93 and is better than soft-DTW centroids on 9 of 12 datasets. Nearest centroids trade accuracy for a much smaller model and faster prediction. Moreover, the selected γ is unstable: on CBF it ranges from 0.002 to 0.19 across splits, and on ECGFiveDays the largest value $\gamma = 10$ is always selected, i.e. there is no reliable default for γ.

4.4 Multistep-ahead forecasting (Table 3 of the paper)

As in the paper, the first 60% of each series is the input and the remaining 40% the target; a one-hidden-layer MLP (256 sigmoid units, Adam, 400 full-batch epochs, hyper-parameters not given in the paper) is trained with the Euclidean loss or with soft-DTW, from random weights or from the Euclidean-trained network, on 13 datasets.

Table 3 reproduces the main claim: each loss wins on its own metric, and when initialised from the Euclidean network the ordering in γ is the paper's (median test DTW reduced by 19–20% for $\gamma \leq 0.01$). Two differences are informative. First, trained from scratch with $\gamma = 0.001$, the network is unstable on some datasets (test DTW 3.2× that of the Euclidean model on Coffee, 2× on Plane), in line with the degenerate alignments reported for soft-DTW training in [11]; the Euclidean warm start removes the problem. Second, the price of shift invariance is large in Euclidean terms: the

Table 3: Average rank (1 = best) of the five models on test, over 13 datasets; the paper's values (79 datasets) in parentheses.

Test metric	Init	Euclidean	$\gamma = 1$	$\gamma = 0.1$	$\gamma = 0.01$	$\gamma = 0.001$
DTW	random	3.69 (3.46)	3.92 (3.55)	2.31 (3.33)	**2.23** (2.79)	2.85 (**1.87**)
	Euclidean	3.92 (4.21)	4.46 (3.96)	2.85 (3.42)	2.08 (2.12)	**1.69** (**1.29**)
Euclidean	random	**1.31** (**1.05**)	1.69 (2.41)	3.46 (3.42)	4.00 (4.13)	4.54 (3.99)
	Euclidean	2.77 (**1.70**)	**1.62** (2.99)	2.38 (3.38)	3.77 (3.64)	4.46 (3.29)

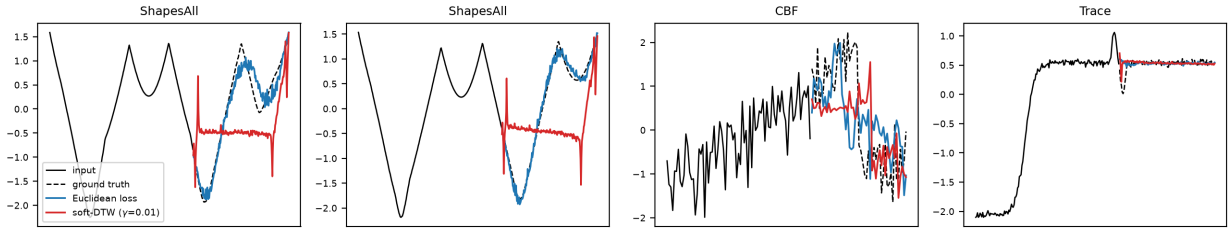


Figure 2: Test forecasts (last 40%) from MLPs trained with the Euclidean loss and with soft-DTW ($\gamma = 0.01$, random init). On ShapesAll the soft-DTW model degenerates into a flat line with spikes, which DTW scores better than the Euclidean forecast.

median test Euclidean error of soft-DTW models is 1.5× ($\gamma = 0.1$) to 3.4× ($\gamma = 0.001$) that of the Euclidean model (Fig. 2). Fig. 2 shows a more worrying failure: on ShapesAll the soft-DTW network (random init) outputs an almost flat line with isolated spikes at the extreme values, and yet obtains a *lower* test DTW than the Euclidean network (6.6 vs 9.3). Free warping lets a whole target segment be matched to a single predicted point of the right height, so degenerate predictions are cheap under DTW — both as a training loss and as an evaluation metric. Such timing and shape errors are not penalised by soft-DTW [5]; controlling them requires a cost on warping, which motivates the next section.

4.5 Other soft surrogates for DTW barycenters

The paper uses soft-DTW as a smooth *surrogate* to minimise the hard DTW barycenter loss. We apply the same test to the variants of Section 2, the debiased divergence and soft-DTW$_\omega$: with the protocol, draws and initialisations of Table 2, each surrogate computes a barycenter, which is scored with the hard DTW loss on the 10 averaged series (as in the paper) and on up to 20 unseen series of the same class (held-out), which penalises barycenters that fit the idiosyncrasies of the 10 series.

Table 4 gives a nuanced answer. *From a random start*, a small warping penalty helps: soft-DTW$_\omega$ ($\gamma = 0.1$, $\omega = 0.1$) reaches the lowest DTW loss (median 8% below soft-DTW $\gamma = 0.01$, better on 9 of 12 datasets) while being 1.6× faster, and with $\omega = 1$ the train loss is no better but the held-out loss is 5% lower, i.e. the penalty limits over-fitting to the averaged series. Penalising warping removes the many degenerate paths from the soft-minimum, which both regularises the barycenter and makes the optimisation cheaper. *From the Euclidean mean*, which is already close to a good solution, plain soft-DTW with small γ remains best and the penalty costs 3–30%: the surrogate that is closest to DTW wins when there is no bad local minimum to escape. The debiased divergence never improves the DTW loss: it only shifts the objective by the self-similarity term $\mathrm{dtw}_\gamma(x, x)$, which pulls towards smooth barycenters and away from the DTW optimum. In short,

Table 4: Barycenters from different soft surrogates, scored with the hard DTW loss (12 datasets $\times$ 10 draws). Median over datasets of the loss ratio to soft-DTW with $\gamma = 0.01$ (lower is better) and average rank among the 9 methods; last column: median computing time relative to soft-DTW $\gamma = 0.01$.

	Random init				Euclidean-mean init				
	train		held-out		train		held-out		time
Surrogate	ratio	rank	ratio	rank	ratio	rank	ratio	rank	ratio
DBA (hard)	1.16	7.1	1.09	7.3	1.03	3.2	1.00	3.2	0.13
soft-DTW, $\gamma = 0.1$	0.95	3.2	0.95	**3.4**	1.06	4.8	1.03	4.8	0.79
soft-DTW, $\gamma = 0.01$	1	4.4	1	5.0	1	**1.8**	1	**2.5**	1
divergence, $\gamma = 0.1$	1.13	7.5	1.08	7.1	1.26	7.3	1.14	7.2	1.32
divergence, $\gamma = 0.01$	1.05	6.0	1.04	5.7	1.01	2.2	1.01	3.3	1.17
soft-DTW$_\omega$, $\gamma = 0.1, \omega = 0.1$	**0.92**	**3.0**	0.95	**3.4**	1.08	5.3	1.04	5.1	0.61
soft-DTW$_\omega$, $\gamma = 0.1, \omega = 1$	1.02	5.1	0.95	4.4	1.30	7.1	1.13	6.9	0.26
soft-DTW$_\omega$, $\gamma = 0.01, \omega = 0.1$	0.96	4.3	0.98	4.6	1.07	5.9	1.03	5.1	0.54
soft-DTW$_\omega$, $\gamma = 0.01, \omega = 1$	1.00	4.3	0.95	4.1	1.32	7.2	1.14	6.8	0.27

no surrogate dominates: the right amount of smoothing and of warping penalty depends on the starting point, which is the same lesson as for γ in Section 4.2.

5 Conclusion

We re-implemented soft-DTW from scratch, verified it against exhaustive enumeration of alignments, and reproduced the paper's barycenter, k-means and nearest-centroid results on 10–12 UCR datasets: the main claims hold, as do the trends in γ. Measuring magnitudes, costs and simple baselines shows their limits: large gains over DBA only from poor initialisations, a 10–15$\times$ computational overhead for the small γ that win, nearest centroids well below 1-NN DTW, and no stable choice of γ. [TODO: one or two sentences on the forecasting and family results.]

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A Additional figures

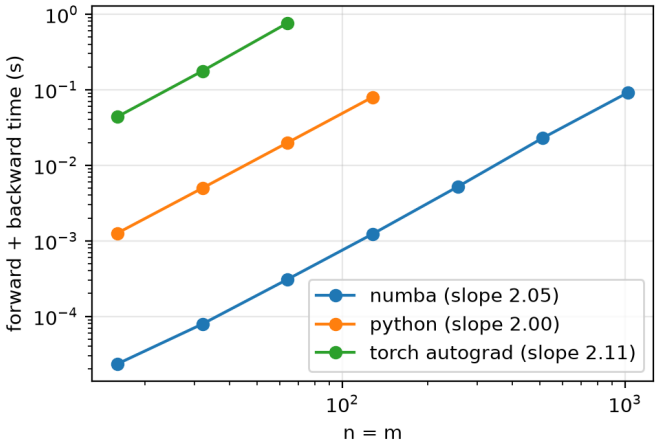


Figure 3: Forward + backward time vs. length $n = m$ (log-log). All implementations are quadratic; Numba is $\sim$65$\times$ faster than the same code in pure Python and $\sim$2400$\times$ faster than a cell-by-cell PyTorch forward differentiated by autograd ($n = 64$).

[TODO: qualitative figures: barycenters on ECG200 (paper Fig. 5), interpolation on GunPoint (Fig. 4), k-means clusters on CBF (Fig. 6), forecasts on ShapesAll (Fig. 1).]